

Elias Berlie

Concerning the Lutheran Free Church and Its Tasks

A Practical Theology of Free Church Polity in Service to the Kingdom of God on Earth

Working English Machine Translation

Machine translation using Aaron Dahlen's

11-step translation process

Last compiled: August 9, 2026

Contents

1	What the Free Church Needs Most	1
2	How We Receive What We Need	3
3	What Our Meetings Are For	5
4	What True Edification Is	8
5	Preparing for the Work	11
6	What result are we seeking?	14

Note on Translation

This working English translation was produced by machine using Aaron Dahlen's 11-step translation process. The process uses artificial-intelligence language tools for transcription, translation, comparison, contextual analysis, and consistency checks against the original Norwegian text.

The resulting English text has not been independently or comprehensively edited by a human translator. The 11-step process is intended to improve the quality and traceability of machine translation, but it does not guarantee accuracy. Difficulties may remain, particularly in archaic language, idiom, historical terminology, and theological expression.

The original Norwegian text remains authoritative. This English text should therefore be treated as a machine-generated working translation rather than a critical or scholarly translation.

The subtitle and descriptive titles for Parts I–VI are editorial additions and do not appear in the original Norwegian text.

Source files, translation materials, and revision history are maintained in the associated GitHub repository.

1 What the Free Church Needs Most

Installment 1: “Folkebladet,” February 23, 1916

Most of us are surely aware that, if we are to make some progress toward the accomplishment of our task as a Free Church, the labor required for this will be both long and arduous.

I believe we do well to be clear that the Free Church is still in its formative stage. The goal is still far off. But even though we see the goal only from afar, we must not lose sight of it; rather, we must keep our gaze fixed upon it and continually set our course toward it. The conditions under which we labor to build a Free Church are by no means easy. And by this I am not thinking only of the fact that we are hemmed in between large, strong church bodies, with money and power and with long-established legitimacy and standing among our people.

I am also thinking of the materialistic spirit by which our age is so deeply marked. But if the calling and the task have been entrusted to us by the Lord, we have only one thing to do: to labor tirelessly and steadfastly toward the accomplishment of the task, whether the work seems easy or hard to us—according to the word of Scripture: “Let us do what is good and not grow weary; for we shall reap in due time, provided that we do not lose heart.”

For those who have grown to love the Lutheran Free Church in this country, and who therefore seek to take part in its work, it seems natural to me to ask: What is it that we especially need in order to labor purposefully toward the accomplishment of our task? And how can we, if possible, obtain what we need?

I know that many kinds of answers to these questions present themselves to our minds. It is natural, for example, to think of a seminary, much money, great and gifted leaders, and so forth.

Well, yes, it is true: we can never accomplish anything as a Free Church without a seminary, money, and men to lead the work.

But it is equally true that these and many other necessary things are not enough.

And what else—what more—do we need? There is a word from God that in former times was often heard among us, but which in more recent times we may have been in danger of forgetting: “Not by might, not by power, but by my Spirit, says the Lord.”

I will therefore answer the question of what we need most in this way: We need the Spirit—the Spirit of God. It is true that we also need much else, such as brotherly love, a sense of responsibility, and willingness to work.

But first and foremost, the Spirit of God.

We need the Spirit of God to bear witness to us that Jesus is our life—the life of the individual and of the congregation; and we need his guidance both to see the way and to receive strength to walk in it.

We need the help of the Spirit of God, through the word of Scripture, to come to a clear understanding and full conviction that the position of the Free Church is biblical, and that

the truths upon which it is built are the very word of Scripture. And the word of Scripture, despite every attack, stands unshaken.

In order to continue with confidence the church work that has been begun, we need full assurance that, so long as we are willing to walk the straight path—in accordance with the conviction and understanding we have gained from the New Testament's presentation of congregational life—the Free Church too is unconquerable, despite all public opinion and all manifest enthusiasm for association.

I have not, however, meant by this to assert that we who today constitute the Lutheran Free Church are unconquerable. No, I am fully aware of our weakness and vulnerability, and that it may not be so difficult to cause us to drift in the struggle we have taken up, which many consider both unnecessary and hopeless.

But my thought is this: if we who now constitute the Free Church fail in our calling and our task, given to us by the Lord, and thus forfeit the blessing he has intended for us through this work, he will see to it that others arise, equipped with the light and power needed for the Free Church principle to be realized more and more, as God's people gather around the free congregation as the right form of God's kingdom on earth.

By this I do not mean to say that the ordering and work of denominational organizations have no value or legitimacy. On the contrary. I willingly acknowledge that within the church bodies there are congregations with believing members, and I also willingly acknowledge that a church body, by reason of its strong cohesion, has many favorable conditions for carrying out vigorous work, at least outwardly.

I mean only to say this: that we who belong to the association called the Lutheran Free Church and have learned to love it, belong there because we believe that the Lord, through the ecclesiastical development and ecclesiastical conflicts among Norwegian seekers after a church home in this country, has led us there, and because we believe that the New Testament points in that direction: free congregations joined together by "the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace."

It is therefore also of exceedingly great importance for us that, under the guidance of the Spirit of God, we receive light concerning the greatness and beauty of our task—the bringing of the congregations to life and their liberation—and receive strength to walk the biblical path in our work of building congregations.

We need, in addition—especially in the Free Church, where no outward bonds exist to hold us together—brotherly love, so that we may be bound together as one, not by factional fences and constitution, not by formulas and laws, but by the strong, holy bond of brotherly love, so that it may be recognized and felt, both among ourselves and by others, that we are a family of brothers and sisters.

And we need a sense of responsibility, so that all of us—the individual friends of the Free Church and the individual congregations—continually live and labor under the consciousness that the Lutheran Free Church's welfare, progress, or decline depends not first and foremost upon the relation of others to it, but upon my own relation to it—the relation of each individual—and upon the relation of my—of our—congregation. Without some measure of

such recognition and awareness, and the sense of responsibility that follows from it, it is surely hopeless to expect any future for the Free Church. And finally—and not least—we need willingness to work, so that we are willing to do something to build our church home.

We must, so far as possible, all take part in this work, so that each and every one of us, according to ability and gifts, endeavors to fill the place in which the Lord has set us, and there to do the work for him with eagerness, willingness, and joy.

2 How We Receive What We Need

Installment 2: “Folkebladet,” March 01, 1916

The question, then, is this: how can we come to share in these blessings, so glorious and indispensable as they are for us?

There may perhaps be one person or another who, without further thought, consoles himself with the belief that we possess them, and therefore need not concern ourselves with this matter, either for ourselves or for others.

I do not think, however, that very many think in this way. Most among us must surely acknowledge that we are unspeakably poor in spiritual life and in everything else that we so deeply need, both in our personal life of faith and in our congregational life.

We therefore feel the importance of the question: how can we receive what we need? It is perhaps not so easy to answer this question.

I believe, however, that many agree with me when, to begin with, I answer: We never receive these blessings and gifts against our will, nor do we receive them without doing something in order to receive them.

Yes, but what can we do? Perhaps not much; but we can do something, provided only that we are willing. We can, first of all, acknowledge our spiritual poverty and our lukewarmness. But this is by no means an easy road to walk. It costs humiliation and suffering, and from that we shrink.

I do not know for certain, but it may be that there has been some inclination among us to settle into complacency both with our own spiritual condition and with that of our congregations. Yes, that is dangerous.

Paul was never satisfied, either with his own relation to God or with that of the congregations. Always more, always farther onward: “I press on to lay hold of it”—“I hasten toward the goal.”

And he exhorts the congregations to which he writes his letters to do likewise: “You also, brothers, become imitators of me!” “Therefore I bow my knees before the Father . . . that he . . . may grant you to be strengthened with power through his Spirit in your inner being.”

Yes, if this deep acknowledgment of our powerlessness and our half-hearted Christianity could seize us, fill us! Then there would be cries for help, and then we would receive help.

To his first congregation Jesus said: “You will receive power when the Holy Spirit comes upon you, and you will be my witnesses both in Jerusalem and to the ends of the earth.”

And of this congregation it is written: “They continued with one accord in prayer.” And they continued in this prayer with one accord until, on the day of Pentecost, they received the power from on high.

He who alone can give us what we most need, also in our Free Church work—he has said to us as well: “Ask, and you will receive!” We can, if we are willing, acknowledge our helplessness and need and lament them before the Lord. We can tell him at least something about what is lacking—not first and foremost in others, but in ourselves, both individually and as congregations.

Certainly he knows it well, he who says, “I know your works,” without our telling him; but he has nevertheless laid down in his word the rule that spiritual blessing reaches neither the individual nor the congregation without earnest prayer. And here, no doubt, lies our great loss: We pray so little, both in the private chamber and in the congregational gathering. I know well that believing people can never cease praying altogether; but I also know that the heart can grow cold, the knees stiff, and prayer many a time become only a prayer for ourselves.

Brothers and sisters, let us attend to this matter. For it is so important.

The kingdom of God that Jesus brought was not intended to be merely a Christianity of individuals. It was intended to be a Christianity of fellowship, in the sense in which we confess in the Third Article: “I believe in the communion of saints.”

It is certainly true that it is as individuals that we come to share in salvation and enter into union with God; but it is not intended that each believer should live his life in God for himself alone, but rather that he should live this life in the blessed consciousness of belonging among the Lord’s great company of children.

According to the New Testament, there can be no mistaking that it is God’s will and purpose that his people should live their life in God as a life in fellowship. Therefore so much is said about “fellowship.”

And Jesus prays for his own that “they may be one” with almost greater earnestness than for anything else.

We may therefore conclude that, for him, this matter has overwhelmingly great importance. Yes, he himself says that he prays for this “so that the world may believe that you have sent me.”

The progress and spread of Christianity depend upon this.

It is therefore important to think of the congregation and the congregations when the question is how we are to receive the gifts of grace without which the Free Church cannot be built. And when it concerns the manner in which these gifts may be obtained, the way is not simply the same for the individual as for the congregation. For the individual, perhaps one of the most important things required in order to receive these gifts is that solitude be sought.

For the congregation, on the other hand, what is required, as already pointed out, is that fellowship be sought—the communion of saints.

Even after the outpouring of the Spirit, it is said of the first Christians: “They held faithfully to the apostles’ teaching and to the fellowship, to the breaking of bread and to the prayers.” Acts 2:42.

They therefore found it necessary to gather with one another in such assemblies, where love for one another and love for the Lord and his cause were the sole command impelling them to gather.

Concerning this matter, the late Professor Sverdrup says in *Collected Writings*, volume 3, page 307:

If free, independent congregations are not to lose something of the power of cooperation, spiritual connection is needed. Free cooperation in everything that can serve the advancement of God’s kingdom at home and abroad is necessary. If it is to take place, then we must understand one another and know one another. We must exchange thoughts and spirit and thus have the bonds of love tied in the freedom of the Spirit. As far as I can understand, genuine Free Church work will be almost impossible under our conditions without a great many free meetings and gatherings.

As may be seen from these statements by Professor Sverdrup, he placed great weight upon the people of the Free Church coming together for free meetings.

And it is a well-known fact among us that quite a number of such larger or smaller meetings are also held, at which it is desired that brothers and sisters from several congregations should gather. This is both necessary and right; for we shall scarcely be supplied in any other way with that power from on high which we must have, if we are to be able to fulfill our task, than by gathering for such meetings.

But I, and perhaps many with me, have observed with concern that the felt need to come together for annual meetings, mission meetings, district meetings, and so forth seems to be declining to an alarming degree. What can be the cause? Could it perhaps be the same cause for which the congregation and the angel of the congregation in Laodicea had to hear these solemn words: “Because you say, ‘I am rich and have abundance and lack nothing,’ and you do not know that you are wretched and pitiable and poor and blind and naked, I therefore counsel you to buy from me—”?

Oh, let us follow his counsel: “buy from him.”

3 What Our Meetings Are For

Installment 3: “Folkebladet,” March 08, 1916

There could be much to say about the reason why our meetings are less well attended than before; but I shall pass over that this time and look somewhat at our meetings as we generally have them.

At times the thought has taken hold of me that our meetings are not always what they ought to be. And on this account the question has arisen: what is the deficiency, or what are the deficiencies, in several of our meetings?

As will be understood, I proceed from the assumption that we intend something, that we will something, when we hold meetings.

For it is also conceivable that meetings may be held without anything real being intended by them.

But what is it, then, that we will?

The answer may perhaps be given: we wish, if possible, to derive some profit for faith and thought. We intend that the individual, through the word and the Spirit, may come nearer to God. Among other things, we intend through our meetings that those who gather may be influenced by the truth toward a deeper recognition of sin and guilt before God, and toward a more childlike and trusting appropriation of grace, of salvation.

And finally, we intend to impart Christian knowledge, deeper insight into the Lord's word and the Lord's plan of salvation for the individual and for the congregation, and a clearer understanding of our life and of the task we have been set to accomplish here in life. In a word: we would so gladly be made partakers of a greater fullness of God's Spirit.

As may be seen, the goal here set as the result of a meeting is rather high. But not too high. It is not unattainable, even though it is not easy to reach. Yet the difficulty involved in attaining this high goal ought neither to frighten us away from holding such meetings nor, in faintheartedness, cause us to lower the demand or comfort ourselves with the cheap consolation that it matters little whether the goal is reached or not.

No, let the high goal stand before our thought and our longing in all its beauty and greatness; and let us, with all the means God himself has entrusted to us, labor and pray that it may be attained.

The truth is, namely, that it can be attained. For of all that is certain, nothing is more certain than this, that "the Lord holds his people dear." No gift is the Lord more willing to give his people than the gift of the Spirit. And when his people gather as children around their Father's table to be sanctified and made fit for their work for him, the Lord is willing to bless.

It is, however, a fact that the experience of many concerning the profit of such meetings is this: that it has often been so small. And by profit I do not mean primarily the more or less powerful stirring which, for many, is the only profit they desire. No, I think rather of what is called spirit in a meeting, of whether we succeed in leading one another deeper into the word, and finally of the abiding effects of the word spoken during the meeting.

What, then, is the reason that the profit is so often so small? What is the reason that many of our meetings are so ineffectual, so poor in spirit and in profit for the participants?

The causes are no doubt many, perhaps. And I do not presume to think that I possess the ability to point out all the hindering causes on account of which several of our meetings bear

so little fruit. But if I could succeed in drawing the attention of our Free Church people to this matter, and if I could moreover point out some of these hindering causes and, if possible, do ever so little toward their removal, the purpose of these words would be attained.

There are certain things in connection with our larger meetings that I wish to mention, but I am uncertain which I should mention first. I therefore point to the hindrances I believe I see in the order in which they present themselves to my thought.

The first great deficiency in at least most of our meetings, I believe, is this: they are far too little prepared through prayer.

I know well that some who read this will object that this is not so, but that believers, prior to the holding of a meeting, pray for God's blessing upon it. Yes, at almost all the meetings I have attended, I myself have heard speakers say that they have asked the Lord to "save, if only one soul, at the meeting." And this, then, is supposed to be proof that the meeting has been well prepared through prayer? To such a claim I will say, quietly but firmly: no!

For in the first place, very few of those who pray for a meeting intend anything definite by their prayer. They pray because they believe it is their duty to do so. Or, if they do intend something by their prayer, there are many who do not know what they intend. And how, then, can God answer such a prayer?

There are no doubt those who will contradict me here also and answer that they both intend something and know what they intend. For, they say, we ask the Lord to save the unsaved, and we pray that God's children may be edified; and then surely we must intend something and know what it is we intend.

Well, yes, I myself have many times prayed in the same manner, but I fear that, nevertheless, I have not truly been clear about what I was asking. What is meant when in prayer we say to God: you must save sinners at this meeting?

I assume that the very great majority who pray in this manner think chiefly of a spiritual stirring perceptible to everyone during the meeting, especially among those who were assumed until then to have been indifferent.

Yes, someone says, but is this not good?

Yes, of course it is. And more than once during the time in which I have taken part in meetings, I myself have experienced the great joy of witnessing such a stirring. And yet—it is not decisive.

Spiritual stirring is not synonymous with "being saved." What is decisive—the fact that a soul in its inmost being turns from the world and sin to God—is not proved by an hour of emotional stirring during a meeting. The stirring that is perceived may be deep and true, but it may also be superficial and deceptive.

It is therefore not certain that all who pray that a "soul may be saved" during the meeting are thinking of, and truly know, what they are asking. They may pray earnestly and mean well, but they do not think deeply enough, not biblically enough. For as a rule, by the expression "the salvation of a soul," one thinks only of being allowed, at the meeting, to witness one or

more persons, with tears and perhaps with a request for intercession, show openly that they have been seized by the effect of the word. And this—as already said—is good and well so far as it reaches. But with many, with most, it does not reach far enough.

Salvation, or perhaps more properly, being made a partaker of salvation, is something else and something more—not merely religious moods, not merely anguish over having acted foolishly, and still less terror of hell, but the heart’s surrender to God, the will at rest in harmony with his will, so that the sinner in the inmost depth of his being says: “I will rise and go to my Father.”

By this I have not said that we should not desire and pray for spiritual stirring during a meeting. No, we can hardly have too much of it—at least not of that stirring which is brought about by a living and Spirit-filled proclamation of God’s word.

For it is a truth confirmed by experience that the word most often makes its way through feeling to the will.

There may, of course, be such natures whose life of the will is best influenced through thought, but they are exceptions, not the rule. Therefore let us rejoice that spiritual stirring is perceptible during a meeting, but let us not overvalue it.

4 What True Edification Is

Installment 4: “Folkebladet,” March 15, 1916

Through the little I have said here about this matter, I have tried to indicate how indefinite and how lacking in a clear aim it is when prayer is offered for “salvation” for a soul.

And I believe that the same is true when prayer is offered for “edification for the believers.” For what is commonly meant by the expression “edification” is that the single person—the individual—may during the meeting be brought into a pleasant feeling of joy and satisfaction with himself or with his Christianity. In other words: joy and a sense of happiness in being a believer, in contrast to “the world.”

Now I do not mean to say that joy over salvation is unwarranted and harmful. On the contrary. I maintain, with God’s Word, that “joy in the Lord is our strength.” But in the first place, it is far from true that “joy in the Lord” is the same as a feeling of pleasant satisfaction with oneself and one’s conversion. No, “joy in the Lord” is the soul’s blessed rest—not in its repentance, conversion, faith, or sanctification, but in the completed salvation through Jesus Christ—procured for all, but received and availed of only by those who bow themselves to God with an undivided mind.

Now it is essentially true that the soul which “believes,” which receives in Jesus Christ salvation from sin and perdition, possesses something that “the world” does not. It is true that where surrender to God has taken place, a great change has occurred—the greatest that can happen to a human being. But this change, by which a person becomes willing to receive salvation, is a work of God himself through his Spirit and Word—a work which the Spirit has accomplished amid much resistance and many hindrances on our part.

“Joy in the Lord” cannot, therefore, be joy over the fact that “I have been converted,” but joy that salvation has been procured for me through Jesus’ atoning death; and when, through the Spirit’s guidance and working, I have learned to make it my own, to rest in it, and to build my whole blessedness upon it—then I possess something of the joy in the Lord. But the others—“the world”—can also receive a share in this “salvation.” For “God wills that all people should be saved and come to the knowledge of the truth.”

That the believers are edified is not the same as being confirmed in the thought that I am so thoroughly converted, or that in my heart I am certain that, if everyone were like me, all would be well in the world. No, “edification” is that, through the working of the Word, I am made to see how poor a Christian I am, how meager both faith and life are—in other words: that my knowledge of sin is deepened, my gratitude to God for salvation increased, and my zeal for the salvation of others made more ardent.

“Edification,” therefore, is this: that I receive more of the mind of Jesus, so that for me, as for him, it becomes “my food,” the wealth and happiness of my life, the secret fountain of joy in my soul, to be permitted to fight in self-denial, to take part in the Lord’s army in the battle against the evil within us—and around us.

But if this is the true “edification” of the believer, it is easy to understand that not very many are inclined to desire it, to pray for it. For it is costly. It costs humiliation, sacrifice, money.

Jesus says: “Take my yoke upon you and learn from me, for I am gentle and humble in heart, and you will find rest for your souls: for my yoke is beneficial and my burden is light.”

Here he says, therefore, that “his yoke” is the soul’s rest; that edification, rest for the soul, is obtained by taking “his yoke,” by learning from him to labor for his cause with something of that mind to which it is “food to do the Father’s will.”

Whether we will admit it or not, it is nevertheless true that we are all tempted to settle ourselves comfortably on earth and to trouble ourselves as little as possible about the crying need in which our brothers in the world find themselves. The “edification” which we here, as God’s people, most need when we gather around his Word at our larger or smaller meetings is this: that we receive more desire and more strength to walk fearlessly on our fixed way, in that life whose wealth and happiness are the joyful self-sacrifice for Jesus Christ’s great, world-liberating task; so that concerning us also the familiar but often forgotten word may become reality, may become truth: “As he is, so are we in this world.”

My meaning, therefore, is that the believers have received true edification during a meeting when they leave the meeting with deeper sorrow over their own powerlessness and wretchedness, with a firmer resolve to cling to grace more childlike and trustfully, and with a more burning longing to be among the ranks of those who have gone out to conquer the world for Christ. The believers are edified when, through the working of the Word, they leave a meeting fully conscious that they, in the one journey they have through life, will follow Jesus Christ.

It will, of course, cost—perhaps much: “And he said to all: If anyone wishes to come after me, he must deny himself and every day take up his cross and follow me. For whoever wishes to save his life will lose it, but whoever loses his life for my sake, he will save it.”

And it may indeed happen that the heart will at times writhe in pain over what it will cost.
But nevertheless—the same heart that found salvation in Jesus says to him in full earnest:

Hymn reference: Hymnary.org, “Din, O Jesus, din at være” by Theodor Wilhelm Oldenburg.

Editorial note: E.B. quotes stanzas 1 and 4 of this hymn. Because the complete hymn would have been familiar within the Norwegian Lutheran context of the period, stanzas 2, 3, and 5 are supplied here to restore the context available to the original reader.

1

Yours, O Jesus, yours to be,
Is my joy and all my honor,
Yours in life and yours in death;
Therefore I will struggle onward,
In your footsteps I will journey,
Finding sweet the hour of battle.

2

Yes, I know that only he can
Find the crown of glory with you,
Glory’s crown and peace of life,
Who, despite all dangers of life,
All the foe’s deceit and darkness,
Faithfully walks in your steps.

3

Underneath the cross I’ll enter,
Bearing it with quiet gladness,
That cross, Savior, which is yours;
Though my path leads through dark valleys,
Still my goal in heaven’s dwelling
I behold with joyful eyes.

4

Lead me where death itself threatens,
Lead me through affliction’s fire,
Through the storm upon the wild sea;
As you will, O dearest Jesus,
If only you, yes, you will be
My own strong supporting staff.

5

Shining in the light of your grace,
Lead me on the road toward the goal

While I wander here on earth;
And when all the cross is ended,
Let me enter into heaven,
Where you dwell in glorious light.

And while we, according to the grace we receive, fight the fight against ourselves and our own wretchedness and against the evil in the world around us, our heart is lifted up in blessed joy at possessing God's unchangeable love in Christ, and we count everything as loss, if only we may keep it. And he himself has taught us that when the battle has been fought to its end and the way of the cross in following him here in this foreign land has been traversed, we will then accompany him into the land of perfection and there be together with him through the long, joy-bringing "Sabbath rest that remains for God's people."

"Where I am, there my servant will also be."

5 Preparing for the Work

Installment 5: "Folkebladet," March 22, 1916

Besides what I pointed out in my previous article, another matter may also be mentioned in connection with intercessory prayer for a meeting: our prayer, and perhaps especially our intercession, is often so powerless, so little heaven-storming and heartfelt.

So often there is lacking that intensity and persistence with which we pray for ourselves when our soul has been struck by some grievous distress. Then we pray because we want something, because we desire something from God.

And if we were clear-sighted enough to see what is at stake—the dreadful ravaging of sin in the world, the threatening advance of the enemy—then intercession for our meetings, which we expect to be a battlefield where the powers of darkness and light meet in combat, would also become far more a cry of distress to the Lord and would bring victory from him.

Yet another matter may also be pointed out in this connection: united prayer, congregational prayer. It is scarcely ever practiced among us. Yes, someone says, when we are gathered for a prayer meeting, several of us pray for blessing upon the approaching edification meeting or mission meeting.

Now, yes, that is well and good where it is done. For not even this is practiced everywhere. But there may nevertheless be little true united prayer in it. It may be such, but it may also be only individual prayer, the prayer of single persons, and nothing more. For in the prayer for "blessing upon the meeting," one person may have one thing in mind and another something entirely different. By united prayer for a meeting I mean particularly this: that a congregation has a living recognition of what it especially needs to receive from the Lord, and that it therefore, as one heart and one soul, longs to obtain this and therefore asks it of him in prayer.

"Again I say to you: Whatever two of you on earth agree to ask for, it shall be given them by my Father in heaven. For where two or three are gathered in my name, there I am in the

midst of them.”

And concerning the apostles before the day of Pentecost it is said:

“They went up into the upper room, where they were staying—Peter and John and James and Andrew, Philip and Thomas, Bartholomew and Matthew, James the son of Alphaeus, and Simon the Zealot, and Judas the son of James. All these continued with one accord in prayer, together with some women and Mary, the mother of Jesus, and his brothers.”

Here we have true united prayer, the prayer that brings blessing, help from God. And for my part I am certain that if more prayer of this kind were practiced before our meetings, these would prove a greater blessing than they now often are.

Could we only remember vividly that the same Lord who has promised to hear prayer when two agree to pray for victory from God over evil—that he stretches out his nail-pierced hands toward human beings and says, “When I am lifted up from the earth, I will draw all to myself”—there would surely be more seriousness in our intercession. The conclusion, then, at which I arrive in the question of preparing our meetings by prayer is this: either no prayer at all is offered, or, if it is offered by one person or another, it is done with so little definite purpose that an answer from God to the prayer can scarcely be expected.

Certainly it is true that “it is God who works in us both to will and to accomplish,” so that our most heartfelt prayer, and that wrestling of the soul with him in which it is said, “I will not let you go until you bless me,” are also his work. Yet, in spite of this, he wills that we should pray with such earnestness as though the blessing of a meeting depended exclusively upon our prayer. But why can prayer be so significant when it too is his own impulse and work in us, brought forth by the Spirit?

My answer to this question is that our prayer means nothing other than that we are willing to receive the help and the blessing which the Lord, in free, unmerited grace, so gladly desires to give us, and which we so sorely need. If our soul has not been so deeply struck by our own and others’ spiritual distress that we ask him with full earnestness for deliverance in that distress, then this is the clearest sign that at bottom we see no danger and therefore do not care about deliverance from God in the distress. Then we shall never receive it. For salvation from sin and spiritual powerlessness is so great that it can be received only by a heart so pressed by this distress that, in comparison with it, it desires nothing else:

“Whom have I in heaven? And when I have you, I desire nothing on earth!”

In this cry we encounter the gathered mind, the undivided heart, for which salvation has become an overwhelmingly great reality, and which therefore partakes of it in so rich a measure.

What I intended by the little I have said here was, then, this: to point out a deficiency which, in my judgment, is so common at our larger meetings, namely, that as a rule they are far too little prepared for by united prayer, congregational prayer. And could I bring individual believers and our congregations to begin thinking over and considering this matter and, if possible, to take it more seriously, I should be deeply glad.

Another very common deficiency at most of our larger meetings is that those who are to take part by giving testimony often speak vaguely, unclearly, and without any aim.

And one of the most common causes of this is that the person concerned is unprepared. That is to say: the person has not studied the Word of God or the subject that is to be treated during the meeting.

But the natural consequence is that in such a case the speaker either does not speak on the text at all, or, if he keeps within the framework of the text, speaks so generally, so vaguely, and with so little point that the hearers are simply bored. And this ought not to be so when the word that is read is “spirit and life.” The Bible says: “Whoever speaks should speak as one who speaks words of God.” And God’s Word concerning the way of salvation is not religious phrases, but clear, definite, concrete truths about sin and guilt before God and about salvation from sin through Jesus Christ. And God’s Word also contains clear, definite truths concerning the life in God which his child is to live here on earth.

Therefore the testimony borne by layman or pastor during a meeting should consist of definite truths drawn from the subject or passage of Scripture that is being treated. No one has the right to excuse himself here with the often-repeated claim that one “has not had time to prepare.” For the one who has had no time for any preparation should not take part by giving testimony. If the matter concerning which we gather for a meeting is not so important that it drives us to as good and thorough a preparation as possible, it is better not to take up any of the meeting’s brief, precious time as a speaker. But not only the one who is to speak at a meeting should prepare himself. The one who is to hear should do the same: prepare himself through prayer and through consideration of the Word of God that is to be treated. By this means the benefit to the hearers would in every case be greater than it otherwise is.

The one who is to speak at a meeting should at least have some grasp of what the word on which he is to speak contains, and he should be able to set forth with reasonable clarity truths contained in the subject before him. Those who come to the meeting to hear have a right to expect this, and many of them really do expect it.

The time should at least be past when, at meetings such as those intended here, one can serve up old, familiar, assorted religious phrases without coherence and without any connection whatever with the subject of the meeting. Certainly this can still be done, and unfortunately it is probably done far too often; but the effects, the fruit, correspond to it. It is therefore careless and irresponsible when someone travels to a meeting to take part by giving testimony without having made any attempt to prepare himself. What would one say of the soldier who went into battle without having inspected his weapons and without having practiced using them? He would at least be able to accomplish little for the king or general in whose army he was to fight against the enemy.

And to take part by giving testimony at a meeting is to enter a holy war. It is to enter war against the prince of darkness and “the spiritual host of wickedness under heaven.”

Paul presents every Christian’s life here on earth as military service. He says:

“Stand, then, with truth girded about your loins and clothed with the breastplate of righteousness, and with your feet shod with the readiness that the gospel of salvation gives; and

besides all this, take up the shield of faith, with which you shall be able to quench all the burning arrows of the evil one, and take the helmet of salvation and the sword of the Spirit, which is God's Word."

And then people will accuse Paul of not understanding what Christianity is.

But if this applies to Christians in general, then it applies to preachers in particular. For such men are not merely rank-and-file soldiers; they should be leaders, officers in Christ's victorious army on earth. And where the armor and weapons are lacking or are not used, we need not wonder at the unsuccessful result of the battle.

None of us, therefore, should go to a meeting with the thought of accomplishing something for our Lord's great cause without serious preparation through heartfelt prayer and a conscientious effort to penetrate the Word of God or the subject that is to be treated during the meeting.

6 What result are we seeking?

Installment 6: "Folkebladet," March 29, 1916

And here no one among us should shrink back from the labor and exertion that such preparation requires. For it repays us well in our own spiritual development and in our fitness for battle against the enemy. If we truly desire that our participation in the Lord's fighting army should yield some result, should be something other and more than a "beating of the air," then preparation is necessary—regardless of what it costs in toil, labor, and prayer. I know very well that we can obtain recognition, and perhaps even praise, from some people without laboring with great exertion to find our own way into the word and without seeking to lead our hearers into it. For what some seek to obtain as the yield of a meeting is that the emotional life of the soul should in some way be set in motion. And the preacher who speaks in such a manner that this is attained often receives praise from superficial persons. But everyone knows that such results can easily be attained without preparation and without prayer—and many are tempted to be satisfied with such things. This, however, is not, and should never be, what we aim at when we participate in a meeting by bearing testimony. Human praise or human blame should have little influence upon us. Our calling is to set our honor in "holding Jesus Christ forth to view," whether this brings us censure or recognition. For what is worth more than human praise or human blame is to receive a friendly, approving glance from him, our great and exalted king, in whose army we have enlisted and under whose banner of the cross we fight.

But his approval is never gained by fighting with self-made weapons, nor by seeking honor for ourselves.

Another matter to which I would also gladly point, because in my judgment it is so significant, is that the person who participates in a meeting should have an aim and a plan for his testimony: an aim, so that he intends something, and a plan, so that he pursues his aim.

We need not listen long to the testimony of some before it becomes clear to us that, at bottom, they aim at nothing and particularly desire nothing, except perhaps this: to speak for the sake of speaking.

That this is wrong should be evident to everyone. And the person who intends nothing by his speech should never occupy the meeting's time. There are others who speak, and in whose testimony it can plainly be perceived that they do intend something. There are spirit and fire in them.

But what do they intend?

Some of them are almost offended by such a question and answer with indignation: What do we intend? We intend awakening. We intend that the people to whom we speak should be awakened. Yes, is this, then, not right? Certainly it is. And I rejoice every time that, in a meeting, I am permitted to hear a testimony borne forth by a heart filled with a burning desire that those who sleep may be awakened.

For awakening is continually needed, so long as the evil powers in the world wind their creeping courses around human beings.

The individual and the Lord's congregation need awakening—such seasons of breakthrough in which life is renewed and made effective. And I will never join those who would dampen the zeal of those whose testimony aims at awakening.

No, let the word of awakening sound forth with clarity and power in our meetings! For the winter cold and the sleepiness are easily perceived everywhere. And when those who long for the manifestations of spring's life, for the disappearance of the night—those whose eyes are weary from watching for the morning and wet with tears from sorrow over themselves and their brothers and sisters in the world—when such persons, with burning and throbbing hearts, speak for awakening in a meeting, then I rejoice. And from my innermost heart I desire that God may bless all those who are grieved over the spiritual distress among our people, and who therefore lament and long, pray and labor, testify and act, that awakening may come! For as a rule it comes only through labor, sacrifice, and prayer. But even if it comes, even if—as I have already pointed out—there arises some more or less powerful spiritual movement, and even if one or more persons indicate that they desire intercessory prayer and guidance, it is not enough. And the testimony that aims only at awakening, only at movement, is imperfect and one-sided.

Spiritual movement, where it is genuine, is only a promising beginning, and nothing more. The apple blossom in spring is beautiful; that is true. But the blossom is not thereby a guarantee of fruit. What is decisive is the summer and the harvest. Then it will become evident whether the blossom became more than a promising possibility. So it is also in the world of the Spirit. Awakening may be promising, but it is not the same as conversion and life in God.

But at times the spiritual stirrings and movements produced by a testimony in a meeting are not even genuine. The movement may be only a superficial intoxication that results in nothing, or in something worse than nothing: it makes the person harder and less receptive to the truth than before. It is therefore so important that the person who speaks for awakening in a meeting should set as his aim that the souls whom he seeks to reach through his testimony should be affected not only in their emotional life, but also in their volitional life, so that, through the working of God's Spirit by means of the word, there may be conversion, change

of mind, and new life in God. Only then has the testimony produced the effect that it ought to have.

It has been shown, not once but many times, that great movements in a meeting fulfilled very little of what they promised. The change of mind that appeared to be traceable in several persons lasted, in many cases, no longer than until the end of the emotionally charged meeting. And then it is certain that the very testimony that was spoken was not what it ought to have been.

The Lord's word now, as before, has power in itself to recreate human hearts, so that it may truthfully be said of them: "The old has passed away; behold, all has become new."

And where the Lord's truth is spoken by living, Spirit-filled witnesses in a meeting prepared and conducted under earnest prayer, it will always bear its blessed fruit, even though no greater awakening is perceived.

For the highest fruit a meeting can bear is that believers are awakened. Someone may perhaps say that believers are awake. Yes, perhaps they are. But they can fall asleep again: "When the bridegroom delayed, they all slumbered and fell asleep." And therefore they continually need to be awakened further—awakened to see their own dullness and the great spiritual peril of their fellow human beings. It may indeed be that the greatest obstacle to the kingdom of God, to "the salvation of souls," is the half-hearted, powerless godliness of those who confess Christ. Is it not a truth established by experience, yet deeply humiliating, that our dear Savior has often offered us an opportunity to "take up the cross," but—we declined?

It did not escape the attention of him whose solicitous gaze is fixed upon us and who asks with concern: "Will you also go away?"

And perhaps it did not escape the attention of those who expect us to be "the light of the world," and who can be won for Jesus Christ only through the testimony given by the life of God's congregation—the life lived in voluntary renunciation and suffering, and in continual, self-forgetting labor for his cause. Christ has never, through the baptism of blood upon the cross, given his life for the salvation of the world so that we should discuss religious questions, attend festivals or meetings in order to enjoy ourselves, and otherwise remain as inconspicuous as possible—"laying up treasures upon earth."

No, what is needed in order that the fire may be kindled of which Jesus said, "Fire I have come to cast upon the earth, and how gladly I would have it already kindled," is that God's congregation should awaken—should see its own danger and the danger of others, and should be penetrated throughout by an "unceasing pain" over the distress of our people and by a glad, battle-ready spirit of conquest whose aim is to win our people for Christ. And where such results are attained through a meeting, there God's Spirit, who is the true power able to produce awakening, has been at work through the word, even though no tumultuous movement could be perceived.

For the awakening of believers most commonly takes place in such a manner—at the beginning, at least—that no one other than the Lord and the individual soul awakened by the word's sharp rebuke knows anything of it.

This will, of course, soon be perceived by others as well, since the believer's outward life and work will bear the mark of the renewal and enrichment of godliness.